MERN → Product Company Interview Roadmap

September–December 2026 | Condensed execution roadmap + daily time allocation

End-of-December Target

Become interview-ready for paid internships / junior software engineering roles at strong Indian product companies. Build and explain a real full-stack application, solve common DSA patterns, handle MERN machine-coding tasks, answer SQL/database questions, and discuss junior-level system design confidently.

Current Foundation

JavaScript	**React.js**	**TypeScript**
Node.js	**MongoDB**	**SkillForge (starting now)**

4-Month Execution Plan

SEPTEMBER	**BUILD + BECOME INTERVIEWABLE** • Finish 20-Day MERN Interview Theory • Finish MERN Coding + Machine Coding preparation • Build and ship **SkillForge V1** • Continue relevant job applications **TIME: 6–8 focused hrs/day** Typical 8h day: SkillForge 4h • MERN prep 2.5h • DSA/System Design 1h • Applications/review 0.5h
OCTOBER	**DSA + SQL + MODERN FULL-STACK** • DSA becomes the main priority; use Striver's curated set • Arrays, hashing, two pointers, sliding window, binary search, strings, linked lists, stacks/queues, recursion, trees • SQL + PostgreSQL fundamentals • Next.js fundamentals • Continue system-design fundamentals + applications **TIME: 6–8 focused hrs/day** Typical 7h day: DSA 3h • SQL/PostgreSQL 1.5h • Next.js 1h • System Design 1h • Applications/revision 0.5h
NOVEMBER	**INTERVIEW DEPTH + SYSTEM DESIGN** • Continue DSA: trees, BST, graphs, heaps, greedy, backtracking, DP + revision • Pattern recognition + explaining solutions aloud • System design: concepts → simple real systems • Finish useful Next.js fundamentals • Docker basics + containerize a project • Improve SkillForge / decide whether a second project is needed • Build/refine portfolio + applications **TIME: 6–8 focused hrs/day** Typical 7h day: DSA 3–3.5h • System Design 1.5h • Machine Coding/full-stack 1h • Project/portfolio/applications 1h
DECEMBER	**PERFORM + CONSOLIDATE** • DSA revision + timed interview practice; reduce new-topic learning • Mock DSA, JS/React, MERN, machine-coding and project interviews • Junior-level system-design interviews • AWS basics: IAM, EC2, S3, RDS, VPC basics, CloudFront, Lambda concepts • Consolidate Docker + deployment knowledge • Polish resume, portfolio, SkillForge and interview stories • Aggressive applications + interview attempts **TIME: 6–8 focused hrs/day** Typical 7h day: DSA 2–2.5h • System Design 1.5h • Mock/Machine Coding 1–1.5h • MERN revision 1h • Applications/projects 1h

Weekly Workload Target

Target: 42–48 focused hours/week. Aim for 6–8 focused hours on most days, with one lighter day for revision, planning, applications, and recovery. These are focused hours—not time merely spent at the computer.

Priority Order

Tier 1 — Must master	SkillForge • MERN theory • MERN machine coding • DSA • JavaScript • React • System Design fundamentals • SQL
Tier 2 — Strong additions	Next.js • PostgreSQL • Docker • AWS basics • Portfolio
Tier 3 — If time permits	Second full-stack project • NestJS
2027 focus	Python • Mathematics • ML • Deep Learning • LLMs • AI Engineering • Research Engineering

Pre-Selected Learning Resources

SQL / PostgreSQL	Jon Avis — SQL and PostgreSQL for Beginners (Udemy)	Structured overview → practice
Next.js	Official Next.js Learn	https://nextjs.org/learn
Docker	Official Docker Get Started	https://docs.docker.com/get-started/
AWS	Stephane Maarek — AWS Cloud Practitioner (Udemy)	AWS fundamentals; no certification-chasing

Rules

• Course/tutorial = mental model; project/practice = actual learning.

• Do not chase technologies for the sake of a longer tech stack.

• Do not wait until you feel 100% ready before applying.

• SkillForge is the flagship project; only build a second project if it adds meaningful engineering value.

• DSA goal = strong pattern recognition and explanation, not a vanity question count.

• 2026 objective = software-engineering employability. Serious AI/ML preparation starts in 2027.

Strategic arc: September BUILD → October THINK → November SOLVE → December PERFORM → 2027 PIVOT TO AI/ML.